

The Head of Steam

Saelunere, Episode Five

Parvo, in the year 756

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It was late evening by the time Lark got to the top of Salador's Slip, and she stood outside the heavy door with her hand up, and then she knocked.

Madame Rooke called her in. She was at her desk with the day's papers squared off in front of her and one hand already moving them into the drawer, and she was plainly an hour from her bed. She did not get up when the door opened.

"Sorry, Madame Rooke, to disturb you so late." Lark had stopped just inside the door and not come any further. "I just thought I would already come back regarding the information which you requested. Is it okay if I come in?"

"Of course, of course. I'm pleased to see that you're so eager to help me in this matter."

"Well. To be honest, I was ready to come here with a lie, but that would be stupid of me, and I realised that, because you of anyone would probably recognise a liar." Her hands had found each other in front of her and would not keep still. "I'm not willing to be any type of a pawn if it comes to giving information to certain guilds, or certain parts of certain guilds, that would help them continue operating in the ways they do currently. And my life has already been compromised by the Porter's Guild. So this information which you requested, if it means

that I'm going to help these certain guild enforcers in any way, I don't need to stay here. I just wanted to let you know that."

Nothing in Madame Rooke's voice had moved when she answered.

"My dear, we haven't even agreed whether you'll be staying here. This is to pay a debt of you already staying in my establishment." The last of the papers went into the drawer. "And as for the guilds, I assure you this is purely a family matter between family members, and whether they're associated with guilds or not is not your concern, I believe."

"You are trying to refuse my offer in exchange for something more valuable to me." It was not a question the way she said it. "And give me nothing in return."

Lark offered herself instead, and got nowhere with it. Being an extra ear in places nobody suspects her of being anything was precisely what she had been asked to do and precisely why she had been picked. She could have a deal if she liked. She could not have one on a promise. A girl with nothing can disappear in the night, and Madame Rooke had already said out loud what would happen to Nell if she did.

Lark looked at the floor between them for a while.

"You probably realise how I'm circling around this topic," she said. "That I know something. So, since I'm a really bad liar. A person named Aeska was performing in the bar. But that's a public name he gave out, and the surname is not something he publicly announced. But, you know, putting two and two together. How many people named Aeska performing in a bar?"

"I mean, this is exactly what I need you to find out. Whether they are Aeska Volan or just simply another bard who happens to have a poorly chosen first name. This is what we do here." She took the spectacles off. "It's no use to me to tell them something they already know. We need confirmation."

Lark tried to find a way round that and did not find one.

"Look." Madame Rooke folded the spectacles and set them on the desk. "If you don't do this task, I will have people that will do it. So should you refuse, it's only going to delay the inevitable anyway, and cause more problems for yourself."

"What is the inevitable that you're talking about?" Lark had not moved off the rug. "Because I don't want to cause trouble to anyone."

"Well, the inevitable is that if this is Aeska Volan, his family will find out about it. That is the ultimate goal here." She said it as flatly as she had said everything else. "Now, the people that I work for are not necessarily his family, but they are searching for him. And the Volans, as I'm sure you're aware, are a powerful family within the city. If they have paid me, they will have paid others. What you are withholding stops being worth anything the second somebody else tells me it."

"What if I got other useful information?" Lark's thumb was going over her

knuckle again. "Maybe I can offer some. Dirt. On certain guild matters instead."

It was a new way round, and she was reaching for it to avoid hurting a man who had trusted her with a surname that was not to be spoken. So she tried to give Madame Rooke the Porter's Guild instead. What had compromised her life was Theodore Blackwood dying, because after he died the Porter's Guild had come looking for anybody who had known him, and that was how they had got hold of her. They had had problems with Theo, and they now wanted somebody to finish his deals.

"This is a start," Madame Rooke said. "Do you know what their deals entail? Or perhaps their connections to anything greater than a debt?"

"Something so big that they're willing to kill people in public for it."

"My dear." Madame Rooke laughed at her, once, and not unkindly. "In this business, that is worth a great deal less than you think it is."

"Look. I'm not so foolish to think that you don't therefore know this Aeska, else why would you be protecting him." She stood up. "I will not sell him to the bidder if you do not sell him to me first. But I will need something to sell instead. So if you have some sort of dirt on the Porter's Guild, some criminal venture, something like that, bring me that. I'm no fool in this."

"I know. I understand." Lark had her hand on the doorframe. "I will return to you tomorrow evening. My apologies."

Out on the street it was gone ten, and she had nowhere to go. Billiam's house was an hour's walk and she could not make herself knock on it. So she went down into the Bellows and found a nook off the main run where the pipes came together warm, and slept there in her coat, and woke with the noise of the city's plumbing still going and every bone in her complaining.

* * *

The coming morning, Billiam went to work.

There was no shift and nobody to work it for. He went down the same streets at the same hour anyway, to find out whether anyone had come back, and whether a place can go back to being what it was if you keep turning up at it. The gate was still locked, just as he had left it, and when he swung it wide the whole yard was too.

Then there were two familiar voices behind him, out on the road.

Alfie was nineteen and Darkin and not much different from Billiam in build or manner, and normally good company on a slow afternoon. Hollis was about fifty,

a human, and had been at the yard longer than anyone except Shrapnel himself, which on a crew of five made him something like the second in command.

"Billy." Hollis came up level with him at the gate and looked past him into the yard rather than at him. "Did you come in yesterday?"

"Well, I was going to, but I found nobody here."

"Yeah. Yeah. Bad business yesterday. Bad business."

"Oh man, it was so bad." Alfie got in front of both of them to say it. "Like there was people that came into the yard and they were threatening and everything and super scary. I hid straight away. And then when I looked up again, Shrapnel was gone and they'd smashed up the office and they looked really mad."

"What kind of people were they?"

"Oh, there was like a big woman, big coat, green coat, and there was a guy, he looked super scary, he had like scars across his face, like blonde hair." Alfie was doing the scars on his own face with two fingers. "Yeah, yeah, scary guys, like guild guys. Obviously guild guys."

"Okay, so was everyone fine? I mean, was anyone injured?"

"Yeah, like I hid. Like I hid in one of the buckets in the corner and then I just came out when everything had stopped."

"Shrapnel told us to go," Hollis said.

He said it to the yard and not to Billiam, and his voice had gone thin and far away.

"I headed out back home. Shrapnel saw these guys turn up. I think he saw what the problem was, he saw that they were going to cause a problem, and he dismissed all the crew and told us to get out of there. Some of us obviously went. But yeah, when we came back, he was gone."

"Okay. Well, then, do you think he will be back today?"

"I doubt it." Hollis shrugged. "Given, I mean. He might be dead. I don't know."

"Why would you say that?" It came out faster than Billiam meant it to. "I don't think he would be dead if they came to take him. Right?"

"Well. Yeah. Maybe. I don't know. Look, I'm just saying I wouldn't expect to see him again."

Billiam took a moment with that one and then went on past it, because he had come down here with a plan and he was going to say it out loud.

"Okay, well then, I'm going to have to do something about that. I'm going to find out what happened. And if you guys could just look after the scrapyard today, I will. I'll come back tomorrow, and."

"Yeah. Yeah, well, I mean, to be honest, we just came to see if we can get our wages paid and then get out of here." Hollis finally looked at him. "I mean, no offence to you, Billy. I respect your dedication. But I'm looking for another job."

“Oh.” Billiam turned to the other one. “Okay. Well, what about you, Alfie?”

“I mean, I gotta work, Billy. I can’t wait around for Shrapnel. We’re not going to get paid.”

“Yeah. I understand.” Billiam was standing in the gateway with the key still in his hand. “Well then, should we just lock up and...”

“We’re going to go through and see if there’s anything left of it,” said Hollis, moving for the gate.

“You can’t be taking anything that’s not yours.”

“Well, we’re owed wages, aren’t we, so it is ours.” Hollis did not stop. “Shrapnel ain’t going to need it any more.”

“Well, you don’t know that.” Billiam was still holding the gate. “He might be back tomorrow, and then we can work here again, then we don’t need to find a different job and all should be well.”

“Look, kid.” Hollis had already started moving. “You’re welcome to think that. You’re welcome to wait around for as long as you want, don’t bother me. But I’m going to get in there and see what I can get out of here, and then I’m going to go find another place to work. I suggest you do the same. You can come in with us if you want, or you can not.”

“I appreciate the offer. But I’ll stay for a bit and figure out what happened to Shrapnel.”

He stood aside and let them both past, and stayed in the gateway listening to the yard come apart behind him, a drawer at a time, a hook at a time. Then he called in that they were to lock up after themselves, and went off across the city to meet Felix without once turning round, and somewhere before the end of the street the noise of it was lost under the carts.

* * *

Calder gave the morning to the College. He works at the desk in his room with the notebook open beside him and gets a decent amount down, and that is what his mornings are. At some point after midday he shut the notebook and went back to his room.

There the plain cloak came out of its box, and the respirator, and the smoked goggles, and all three went into the bottom of his pack. He put them on in a stairwell off an alley two streets from the College, where it is dark and nobody comes. The person who came back down out of it was not the person who had gone up.

Getting word to his crew is not a fast business. They are not sitting in the dark under the city waiting for him to turn up. There is a mark he leaves in a place they pass, and a day or so later they are where the mark says. That afternoon it put both of them in the wide part of a service tunnel with their backs to the way he came in, arguing about the price of something.

Dunmore is a very large man built the way a door is built. Penn is small and young and ratty and has the general air of somebody who has been thrown out of better tunnels than this one.

Calder walked up behind the pair of them and put a hand on each shoulder.

“Oh, who the f -”

Dunmore stopped mid-word as he came round and found Mr C standing behind him.

“Oh. Mr C. How’s it going?”

“It’s been a while,” Calder said. “I would need you guys to do something for me.”

“Right. Yeah, no worries. We got you. We got you.”

“So I’m starting to get involved into something, but I would need more information on the target, so to say. So I would want you guys to split up and gather a little bit of info. Whatever you can gather up.” He turned to the smaller one. “Penn. I think if you can go and keep an eye on a building for me, and see what is going on over there. Is any people going inside. Is people coming outside.”

He described the building. He said what street it stood off and how tall it was and what it looked like from the road. He did not say who owned it and he did not say what he wanted with it, and Penn did not ask.

He could not have said, either, not with any confidence. There was a name he had picked up somewhere in the last few days that sat uncomfortably close to something he knew about that house and had told nobody, and a hunch with nothing under it is worth exactly the price of having a boy watch a door.

“Out in the Outlines, is it?”

“Yes. And you don’t need to go inside the building.”

“Yeah, I can do that.” Penn nodded too many times.

“Good. And then, Dunmore, I would want you to do a little bit more on the footwork.” Calder had to stop for a second there. “But also gathering information on the guild. The Porter’s Guild. I have heard that they have taken some person into custody. If you have any way to ask people around if this is true, what happened to him, where they are holding him, that would be extremely handy.”

“All right. All right. I can ask around.”

He said it straight away and he said it easily, and there was something underneath it anyway, a half beat where the big man’s weight went from one foot to

the other before he answered.

“But yeah, you don’t need to poke too much,” Calder said. “You don’t need to go inside the guild. It would be too dangerous, too risky. You can just keep going by the spire over there and see what’s going on, and then keep asking the underground as well.”

“Yeah. Yeah. So someone’s held there in the tower, you think.”

“Yes.”

There were two names he could have given him at that point, and he had them both in his mouth, one of them a barman and one of them a scrapyard owner, and either of them would have cut Dunmore’s work in half.

He gave him neither.

“Look, boss, the thing is, with the Porter’s Guild, right.” Dunmore had scratched the back of his neck and left the hand there. “I don’t know if you know, but a lot of the Porter’s Guild is pretty, let’s say, mixed up with a lot of, I don’t know what you call it, the underworld. You know what I mean? But like, a lot of the Porter’s Guild’s got a reputation. Not like with the Guild of Engineers, they’re all prim and proper, right, they don’t deal with us. With us folks who operate slightly around the law. But the Porter’s Guild, they got some folks who are a lot more willing to bend the rules when it comes to strict laws and city policy and that sort of stuff. So the problem with looking into them is that a lot of people what deal in these sort of circles have their own connections to the Porter’s Guild as well. And I’m just saying it might cause a bit of a stink if we start asking around too much. Before you should know, you know?”

“I understand.” Calder let him have that and then came back at it anyway. “It would be very handy to know the locations, or get any hint of the location of these two persons, and whether they are even alive any more.”

“Sure.” Dunmore thought about it for a moment. “What I can tell you is, you know the Head of Steam? Pub out next to the Furlong. That’s the Porter’s Guild haunt, owned by an ex Porter’s Guild guy, and it’s their number one. Almost a clubhouse for the guild, if you know what I mean. You want information on the Porter’s Guild, you might want to head there. Ain’t no use me and Penn going, on account of we’re known faces down here.”

“The Head of Steam.”

“That’s the one.”

“All right. I’ll do my own investigations, you do what you can. And Penn’s task is easier, and should be safer.”

“No worries, boss.” Dunmore was already turning away. “How do we get word to you? Normal way? Drop? You got some special situation?”

“Nah. The normal way is fine. Leave it at the usual place.”

“Right. We’ll get on it.”

He went three steps with them and then he was not there. A branch tunnel took him sideways out of the lamplight without either of them hearing it happen, and when Dunmore turned round to say one more thing there was nothing behind him but pipework. Penn looked at the dark for a while after that. Then up, and out, and into an alley where he took the goggles off and the respirator off and the cloak off, and folded all three of them into the pack, and walked the rest of the way to the Plumb and Bob at a perfectly ordinary pace with his hands in his pockets.

* * *

Aeska went out that morning and bought a disguise kit.

The professional sort, which is a flat case the size of a writing box with the whole of a face in it. Pots of cream in four skin tones and a flat brush for each. Spirit gum and the solvent to take it off again. Hair on gauze, in beards and brows and sidewhiskers, laid in tissue. A stick of modelling wax for the bridge of a nose. Twenty-five ducats. He had made a ducat and a mark the night before, and he paid it without arguing.

He came into the Plumb and Bob carrying it in bags. Lark was already there, in an empty room at an hour when nobody drinks.

“Oh. Lark, hi. Come in, come in.” He went past her towards the stairs with both bags swinging. “I need to put the stuff down, so walk with me.”

“Hey.” She fell in behind him. “You probably shouldn’t be here for too long any more. Because, remember what I told you about Madame Rooke?”

“Yes. Did you sell me out?”

“I did not.”

He stopped on the stairs and waited.

“However. By tomorrow evening I have to give some sort of information to her, because I owe her a debt. I mean, I am speaking the truth. I did not sell you out.”

Aeska studied her face carefully. “You don’t sound very convincing.”

“What I mean is that I did not give out your surname. I told her what was public already, that a person named Aeska was performing here on Kinsdae.” She had both hands on the rail, and she was watching him for disappointment she did not want to find, caught between him and the woman at the top of the bathhouse. “She’s very smart, Mr Aeska. She understood the context clues, and she knows

that I'm protecting you. However, she also said she will send someone else to find out about this, if I don't give her what she needs."

"Well, yes. You weren't lying." He said it lightly and went on up. "From the sound of her, she is very good at finding out information one way or another."

"She talked about family." Lark had stopped at the top of the stairs. "I think your family wants to find you."

He put the bags down on the bed in his room and stood over them for a moment before he turned round.

"I have had a run-in with one of my father's enforcers already, before I met any of you. Let us call it that." He did not turn round. "So no, this does not come as a surprise. They are really trying to get me. Though I would not think my father is behind most of it."

"No, however." Lark came as far as the doorway. "Madame Rooke, I don't think she's a bad person necessarily, or that she's standing with any guild specifically. Maybe she could be useful to us, because if she gets information, maybe we can gain some as well."

"I don't know this Madame Rooke." Aeska was pulling things out of the bags and setting them on the bed as he talked, and not looking at any of them. "But I assume you didn't really give her the information she wanted. And you said you have until tomorrow evening."

"Yes. But. Mr Aeska." Lark had her arms folded and had them folded tightly. "What if I told her that it was you in the bar? What would happen?"

"Well. That would mean I would no longer be able to stay here. And that would also mean that I might not see any of you again."

"Then that's not going to happen." She looked straight up at him, suddenly, with sharp eyes. "I'd rather give my own head to her than yours."

Aeska looked back at her for a while. Her wrapped arms were folded hard and her jaw was set. A head and a half shorter than him, she had walked out of the bathhouse last night with nothing and slept in a pipe run rather than come back with his name in her mouth.

"Let's hope it doesn't come to that. I believe you." He went back to the bags. "Let's for now find some information. And let's be honest, if it comes down to that, it's still better for you to give her the information she needs, rather than at the cost of your own head."

Something went across Lark's face at that, a small spark of it, surprise at a gesture she is not used to being on the receiving end of.

"I'm not a good liar. So if I try to lie, we would all be in way bigger trouble."

Aeska smiled, just slightly.

"I can see that. And it's probably better for you not to lie to someone like

Madame Rooke, because she will probably find out one way or another that you're lying to her. It's better to give the truth."

* * *

Fexfield Scrappers is in the Core, and Felix got there first and stood outside it long enough to hear what it was.

It was working. That was the whole of the impression and it was a strong one. A scrapyard that is working sounds like a factory, a steady grinding and banging that does not stop for anything, with men's voices somewhere underneath it. Claringbold's had gone quiet in one afternoon and stayed quiet. This place had not missed an hour.

Billiam came up the street and found him there. A brick warehouse two or three storeys tall, a proper front door, the name painted on a sign above it, and a yard round the back that you cannot see into from the road. It is about as far from Claringbold's as a business in the same trade can get.

He told Felix what he had got out of the morning, which was that it had gone the way they thought. They came for Shrapnel, they took him, they smashed the place. Nobody else was hurt.

"If we go in here, I would pretend to be looking for a new job. But I'm not sure how much we should say about what happened with Shrapnel."

"Let's not really talk about what happened there at Shrapnel."

"Well, we're going to need some kind of an excuse, then. I don't know if you feel like you would also pretend that you want to get a job here, or."

"Well," Felix said, "I do need a job."

"Yeah. Right." Billiam considered that. "So we don't really have to lie."

They went in the front, the way a customer would, and the inside of it was the part that did the damage. Racked, labelled, swept. Machines coming apart in bays with their pieces going into bins that somebody had taken the trouble to mark. It was the same trade Billiam had worked all his life and none of the same habits, and he found he was embarrassed on Claringbold's behalf.

A very big man in a leather apron near the door turned round to look at them.

"All right. How can I help you?"

"Ah, good morning. My name is William, and me and my friend here were trying to see if we could work here."

The big man looked them over, and looked at Felix rather longer. Felix's clothes are better than anything worn by anybody on that floor.

“Well, we always need people down here. So I guess you can go see the boss. Lucile. She’s up the stairs.”

Upstairs was more workshop than office, with a bench down one wall and a mechanism in pieces on it under a lamp, and a woman working at it with her back half turned to the open door. The two of them stood outside long enough to be noticed.

“Hey, don’t stand at the door, come in.” She put the tool down. “All right, what are you doing here?”

Billiam gave her both their names and asked whether she was taking anybody on. She said she always needs people, and asked what they had done before, and he told her a few years at another yard, and the Guild of Engineers, and that he was therefore a highly trained individual.

“Aye. What scrapyard was it?”

Billiam had not thought that far ahead, and it showed on him for about a second.

“Oh. Yeah. It was Claringbold’s Yard, actually.”

“Oh, aye, aye, aye.” Something in her face opened up. “How’s it going?”

“Yeah, we’ve had some ups and downs. But, you know. The scrapyard is still running.”

It was not a good lie and she did not buy it, and she did not pull on it either. She had decided to keep it for later.

“All right, well, good to hear. Shrapnel’s a good lad. We do a bit of work together, me and him, so it’s always good to see one of his.” She pointed at Felix. “What about you? You don’t look like no scrappy I’ve ever seen.”

“Well, I’ve mostly done paperwork. But I just really need a job.”

“Aye, that’s fair, that’s fair.” Her chin came up a little. “How are you with numbers and that?”

“I can work with numbers, yeah.”

“Could I ask you something, Lucile?” Billiam said. “Which guild are you associated with?”

The room went a very particular kind of quiet.

“Yeah. Look. Especially don’t talk really about the guilds around here.” She had picked the tool back up. “You probably know from Claringbold’s that the Corewright’s Association is normally the people what we’re supposed to pay our dues to. The less you know about that, the better.”

He tried it again from another side, got the same wall, and asked whether there were any vacancies in upper management.

She put the tool down and looked at him properly for the first time.

“Look. Me and my brother run this place, right? It’s been a family business

for a long time, and one of the ways we got about that is by keeping it in the family.” She waved a hand at the whole floor and the noise coming up through it. “And no offence to you, like, but I don’t know you from Adam. You just walked in off the street. You could be guild spies. You could be from a rival yard. Like Claringbold’s.”

“I am from Claringbold’s.”

“Exactly. So I’ve got no reason to trust you at this point.”

“Well. That’s fair. I’m slightly offended by that, but okay.” He had gone a bit pink.

“Look, I like a friendly guy, it’s all right.” She had her arms folded. “But no offence to you, you look like you’re coming in with an ulterior motive than just getting work.”

Billiam stood there in the middle of the workshop with two people watching him.

“You know what? Yeah. I think you’re right.” He put his hands somewhere and then put them somewhere else. “I do want work. But look. You said you were on good terms with Shrapnel. He was taken from the yard yesterday, by some people from the Porter’s Guild, and I have been trying to find out why, and where they took him. I was hoping I could find that out here.”

Lucile Fexfield walked past the pair of them and shut the door.

“So. You two.” She stayed by it with her hand still on the handle, hunting for the word she wanted. “You know anything about Shrapnel’s other work?”

“No.”

“Right. Well.” She came back into the room. “Let’s just say there’s a couple of contracts that probably keep off the books a little bit. He had a couple of deals with, let’s say, some friends of ours. Mutual friends, me and him. Pretty lucrative, makes a lot of extra cash on the side. But you try and keep that kind of thing away from people like the Corewright Guild, because they’d take a big fat percentage of the pay if it comes out.”

“That actually makes a lot of sense, yeah.” Billiam was two beats behind and catching up fast. “Why would the Porter’s Guild be then getting involved, if it’s just the Corewright’s Association that would take the.”

“Well, since you know it’s got something to do with the Porter’s Guild. They’re the clients. They’re the ones we’re selling to.”

“We?”

“Me and Shrapnel.”

“Oh.” Billiam had stopped moving entirely. “I thought just Shrapnel. I see.”

“Oh, shit.” She looked at him flatly. “Now I’ve got to kill you.”

Billiam laughed. It came out about a second late and it came out wrong, and

it stopped almost as soon as it had started.

"That's a joke, right?"

"That's a joke." And then she did laugh, properly, and after a moment he joined in. "Now, look. The fact that Shrapnel's been taken away is pretty concerning to me, because that sounds like something's gone wrong. We had two in here this morning trying to ask questions and that, but we just got rid."

"Was it a big lady and a blonde guy?" Felix said.

She stopped.

"Yeah. Yeah, it was."

"Those are the people that took Shrapnel."

"Ah. Right." She took that in, and then gave them the thing they had come for without appearing to notice she was doing it. "Well, them guys are the ones that broker the deal for the Porter's Guild. They come here and they pick up the merchandise and they make the payments. And I'm guessing that Shrapnel couldn't deliver. If he's disappeared and they came in and took him, then that's probably the reason, right?"

"Well, do you know anything that we could do to get him back?"

"You're going up against a big guild there." She shrugged. "But if he's been held anywhere it'd be in the Porter's Guild spire. And good luck getting in there."

"Yeah. It would be tough. But I don't want to give up on Shrapnel."

"Hey. I respect that."

They both went at her after that for a while and a how, and got neither. She heard them out with her arms folded, looking from one to the other and pricing them. Then she turned her shoulder to Billiam.

"I think you look like you might be a little bit more put together." She said it to Felix. "No offence, kid. Situation is, if they got your man Shrapnel and you want to get him back, maybe you can trade for him. Seems like he didn't deliver. And if you've got the goods they want, then maybe they'll just trade him back. I presume you ain't got them, because you probably wouldn't be here if you did. That's a lot of money."

"There's one thing I don't understand," Billiam said. "If it's money they're after, why take him at all?"

"You're not following." She put her hand flat on the bench. "They pay money. They don't need money, they've got plenty of it. They need the cores. And there's only a few of these."

She heard herself say it and stepped back a foot.

"There's a limited supply, let's say, of this particular merchandise that they want. So if Shrapnel ain't delivered his part of the bargain, they can't get it anywhere else."

“Right.” Billiam turned his cup over. “Hmm. No. I’m not really following.”

That was the end of it for him, and he knew it while he was saying it. He thanked her for her hospitality, and said that Felix was, as she had said herself, way more put together, and that maybe this was not the right place for him.

“All right. Nice to meet you, kid.” She got the door for him. “Look, you need a job down here, there’s work for scrappers if you can scrap. You come back, all right?” She put a hand on his shoulder on the way past. “You take care of Shrapnel, all right? He’s a good guy.”

Felix stayed.

He sat with her two hours over the ledgers of a working scrapyards, and he knew every line of what he was looking at, and told her two things about her own bookkeeping that she had not known and was glad to hear. He found nothing else. Whatever the other set says, it was not coming out of a drawer for a man she had met at nine that morning. What he walked out with instead was a chair in the room where the paper lives.

“All right. You know your stuff well enough. Maybe turn up tomorrow and you can do a bit of an audit, check out what we’ve got here. Maybe find some ways to save some money for us.”

“Yeah. I’ll see you tomorrow then. Thank you.”

* * *

The five of them came back together in the Plumb and Bob in the late afternoon, in the last quiet hour before a tavern starts filling.

“We gathered some information.” Billiam got his elbows onto the table. “We talked to the manager of the facility, Lucile Fexfield, and she knows Shrapnel. She kind of works with him. And she thinks that Shrapnel was taken because he might not have delivered upon his promises to the Porter’s Guild. So it sounds like some shady business has gone wrong.”

“It must be about the essence then.” Aeska had come down with his coat still on. “This is what we, if we can piece together the clues that we have. There’s some machine parts with essence delivered to both scrapyards, and it seems that the Porter’s Guild is really looking for information regarding these essence.”

“Yeah.” Billiam turned his cup round. “They seem to be quite desperate to get those cores.”

“If we see what they can do, then I can understand that. These cores have killed a man, and well, almost got the three of you killed. So it must be something

very important, then.”

“Yeah. And so I thought that the murder of Theodore was their plan.” Billiam had both hands flat on the table now. “But maybe it’s just a small part of it, if they still need more weapons.”

“Well, we don’t know who murdered Theodore. We don’t know their motives yet. But we know that.”

“We know it was someone from a guild,” Billiam said. “And that the people that are trying to cover it up seem to be either from the Guild of Engineers or the Porter’s Guild. So they must be in cahoots of some sort.”

“I have a theory.” Aeska had his hands flat on the table. “The people at the Guild of Engineers are behind the murder of Theo. The Porter’s Guild are opportunists. They have worked out what the new essence can do and they are digging for every way of getting their hands on as much of it as possible.” He turned his glass a little. “Look at where they have been going. Scrapyards. Machinery that has already been thrown away. I think they are gathering it up to build something of their own, and I think they are paying for second-hand scrap in cash because none of it is going anywhere near a ledger.”

“You sure know a lot about all this,” Billiam said.

“I used to be in the Guild of Engineers. I know what these cores are, and I know what they can do.”

Billiam remembered something then that he had been carrying around for two days with nowhere to put it. Shrapnel had stood in front of that machine in the yard and told him the cores in it were better than ordinary cores. Not more of them. Better ones. New.

For Calder that was a sentence that rearranged a piece of the world.

There is one kind of essence core. There has only ever been one kind, the way there is only one kind of brick, and one of them will run a bullyboy or a howl on its own, which is the whole reason they cost what they cost. To be told that somebody had made a better one was to be told that a thing he had understood since he was a child had a door in it that he had never noticed.

He thought about the tunnel under the Bellows, and the way those howls had come.

“The howls that we encountered.” He had to work out how to ask it. “Would those be easily run on the normal cores, or would those need more premium ones?”

Nobody had to answer that one. Everybody at the table who had been in that tunnel had seen how fast they were.

“Fifty and thirty,” Calder said. “That many, you are either building one very large machine, or a bomb. Or an army of those fast howls.” He let it sit for a second.

“That would be horrendous.”

“And these cores are new to me as well.” Aeska nodded slowly. “At the Guild of Engineers we only ever dealt with the ordinary kind.”

“Essence cores are made by collecting essence and harnessing it somehow.” Billiam looked round the table. “Wouldn’t that be the College of Arcanographers? Or just the engineers?”

“The Corewright’s Association make the cores.” Aeska turned his glass. “But I would assume the College has a hand in developing them. Making them more efficient. Making them stronger. And that would explain the relationship between my father and yours.”

It was a good theory and it was the wrong shape, and Calder knew why inside four seconds. It was the one subject in the whole affair on which he was the expert in the room.

“Not quite,” he said. “The College studies magic. Cores are just a box to put magic in, and nobody at the College is interested in making a better box. That is an engineering problem. The College does the big picture, the theory, the things nobody has a use for yet.” He turned his glass a quarter turn on the table. “So if the College is in this at all, it isn’t because somebody wanted a better battery. There is something more behind it.”

“Yeah.” Aeska sat back. “That’s what I thought as well.”

“So maybe these improved cores were made by someone who has plans for them.” Billiam had gone off on his own line. “Or maybe they were made, and then they fell into the wrong hands.”

And then he got to the part that had been bothering him all day.

The machine he had stripped down at Claringbold’s was a prototype. Shrapnel had used that word to him. A thing built as an attempt, that had not worked properly, and had been scrapped. But a prototype of something that classified does not get carted out the back of the Guild of Engineers and sold to a salvage yard on the edge of the Stacks, and it does not go to Fexfield either, and yet it had gone to both, and somebody had made that happen.

“Theo,” he said.

“Yeah, that’s what I was thinking as well,” said Aeska.

“Too many puzzle pieces,” Calder said. “And not enough of a picture.”

“Are we now sure,” Lark said, “that this new essence power is classified information currently, and not many people, even in the guilds, know it, you think?”

“I can tell you for certain that none of it is public.” Aeska leaned in on that one. “And I think that is the whole of it. The new cores are why Theo was killed. They are why Shrapnel was taken. They are why the Porter’s Guild are running amok over anybody who so much as knew the man. We have found the source of

the problem. Everybody is looking for these cores.” He turned to Felix. “And your new employer is withholding a good deal more than she let on. You are sitting in her paperwork from tomorrow. Find out what you can about the fifty that was meant to go to them, and get into her good graces while you do it.”

Then he turned the other way, to Lark.

“And it seems, I think, that you have your information to give to Madame Rooke. That does not concern me.”

“I just don’t know how much she already knows.” Lark had not touched the water in front of her. “It would be kind of good to get a name from the Porter’s Guild. Someone who is sort of in charge there, looking for this essence now, someone who’s desperate to keep it, because then Madame Rooke would have some information against them, and that would be valuable for her to keep.” She looked up. “I just mean that we don’t have any names from the Porter’s Guild.”

“No,” Aeska said. “That’s true.”

Calder had been waiting most of the afternoon to put his own card down.

“Do you know a place called the Head of Steam?”

Lark did, but she had never been. Mira went there sometimes, to meet other Porter’s Guild crew heads, and that told her most of what she needed to know about who else went.

“I heard that name,” Calder said, “and I heard that there could be high-end people going over there. So maybe we could get some names from there. But I think the problem would be to go inside over there, and then.”

Aeska had heard of it too, and only one thing about it: that there is no music in it. A clubhouse rather than a tavern, all drinking and gambling, out on the edge of the Furlong a short walk from the Porter’s Spire.

Lark said again that this had to be the last night they met here, and this time somebody had an answer. It was Billiam, and he got it by saying out loud the thing he had spent all day refusing to think: that Shrapnel was not coming back, that the crew had gone, and that there was therefore an empty yard with a gate and a lock on it and nobody left to mind who used it. So Claringbold’s it would be, from now on.

It was coming up on three or four in the afternoon, and below them the room was starting to take its first customers of the evening.

“Well,” Aeska said. “I have to perform tonight.”

“You can’t stay here, Aeska.”

“Don’t worry. I have something for that.”

He played somewhere else that night, and he played in a false nose. Nothing he did could hide him, because a stage is the one place in the city where being looked at is the job, so instead he went the other way and built somebody. Brows

with a heavier weather in them. A beard in a cut he would not have been seen dead in a year ago. A nose with an argument in the middle of it. The man who walked off those boards a ducat and a mark better off had never been seen in Parvo before, and he packed his lute early, because he had somewhere to be.

* * *

They had decided to go in in separate groups, with Aeska last and alone.

“Mr Aeska, we need to be careful not to be linked together now, us two,” Lark had said, worrying at it, and Aeska had agreed at once, given the position both of them were in.

“And I’m not going in directly,” Billiam said. “I’ll scout the area, see if I recognise any people. Stay at a distance a bit.”

The Head of Steam sits on the edge of the Furlong, under a steam clock the size of a cartwheel, with the Circular going round on its poles overhead and the carts crawling past below. The building is wide and low and two storeys, and from across the road the four of them watched it swallow people faster than they could count them.

Lark pulled her scarf up over her hair and most of her face.

Billiam did not go in. He picked a spot in the crowd across the way and set about counting faces through the door, and inside five minutes he had lost that argument. Too many people. Too many doors. So he went round the side to the alley the serving staff use, and stopped at the mouth of it, which is the last few feet where a person can stand and still look like somebody waiting for somebody. Past that it is all bins and back doors, and a stranger standing among them is a stranger with a reason.

Calder went in as himself. Ordinary clothes, long sleeves, gloves, nothing about him worth looking at twice.

“Mr Felix,” Lark said, “I have an idea. Maybe we can head in together. I have a pretty good sight on people. Maybe if you can go to a table, I’ll get you a drink from the bar, and I’ll just try to scout faces while I do that.”

“Yeah, that sounds good.”

“We go different tables?” Calder said.

“Yeah. Let’s just split up close to each other. But just split up, just in case.”

* * *

The inside of it hit Calder in a specific order.

First the noise and the crowd and the size of the room, which is larger than it looks from the street. Then the balcony running round above, with private rooms behind it. Then the Porter's Guild paraphernalia over every wall, rope and hooks and tackle nailed up like regimental colours, the way a soldiers' bar hangs its own trade on itself.

Then the coats, dark forest green, and for a second and a half the bottom went out of the evening. He had last seen that colour on two people in Oblong Square. Here it was on a third of the room, because it is simply what a Porter wears, and he had walked into the building where all of them drink.

Behind the bar stood a steam contraption of some ambition, all brass and linkages, working the pumps and pulling the pints. In front of it stood a tall balding barman wearing a monocle.

Calder bought a beer for a penny and got back a wooden tankard with a head on it like a snowdrift, and then he stood at the bar and drank it and looked at the room, and the room opened up for him.

Most of these people were just people. Seven in ten were drinking after work, some Porters and some not, and would go home and do it again tomorrow. The rest were not. A quarter of that room, near enough, had the look he has spent these last few years learning to read in the other half of his life: men who do not have employers, who sit with their backs to walls, who watch a door without appearing to. Some of them were wearing the green. One of them in particular he would have described as a man who beats people in alleys for money, and that man had his guild coat on over it, and nobody in the place thought anything of either fact.

Then he looked up.

There are five doors off the balcony. Four of them are good doors, decent, decorated, the doors of a pub that charges for a private room. The fifth is at the end of the corridor and it is not the same. It has an ornate frosted glass panel set into it and a level of finish that the other four do not, and it has been built to tell you, from downstairs, without a word being said, that whoever is behind it is worth more than whoever is behind the other ones.

All five had drinks going up to them. Servers came through the crowd with loaded trays and took the stairs and knocked and went in and came out empty, one after another, all evening.

The last thing he worked out was the game.

Half the tables in the place were playing it, three dice and a pile of coppers, and he knew it on sight. It is called *Runs*. It started as a Porter's Guild game and it is played in every tavern in the city now, and there are a great many worse ways

of getting into a conversation with people who do not want one than sitting down at a table and losing money to them slowly. He had done it before.

Felix took a table with a clear view of the upstairs doors. Lark paid a penny for a drink for him and carried it off into the crowd by the long route.

The tables at the Head of Steam are the long benched kind where six separate conversations sit shoulder to shoulder and none of them hear each other, which is the sort of room Lark knows from her time on the Brassline. She went the long way through it, carrying the drink, listening to the loudest tables first and getting nothing out of any of them but men shouting about nothing. By the time she came out the other side she had it the right way round. Loud men have nothing to lose by being heard. The ones worth hearing were folded into the corners with their heads down and their shoulders turned in.

She moved towards one of those and could not get near enough, and tried to read the faces instead, and could get no further than the obvious. Business. Business they did not want overheard, conducted in the middle of the largest public room in the district, because a man who sits in a corner of a crowded pub can watch every door in it at once.

Then Calder spoke into her ear from across the room.

He had seen her working the crowd and had put a few words into her head, and had the manners to start with a warning.¹ *Lark. Don't get scared.* Then the tables he had marked, and which ones, and why: that those were not regular people, that he had a feeling about them. Then the balcony. Five doors, servers going up to all of them, and one of them a great deal fancier than the rest. Important people. Paying to be private.

Lark almost dropped the drink she was carrying, because nobody had ever spoken inside her head before.

She got it to Felix without spilling it, and sat down, and relayed the lot.

"Calder says that table in the corner is worth watching. Underground folk, maybe. Bad dealings." She put the drink down in front of him. "You could get in there if you knew how to play their dice game. Do you?"

"Unfortunately not." Felix looked over at the table anyway, and went on looking at it after he had stopped meaning to.

* * *

¹**Message.** A spell that puts a few words directly into one person's ear across a room, unheard by anybody else, with room for a short answer. It requires the caster to point at the person he is speaking to, which is why it is usually done with a hand already busy doing something else.

Billiam was about twelve feet up the side of the building.

He had waited in the mouth of the alley until two of the serving staff came out for a smoke, and waited longer while they had it, and waited again until they went back in and the alley was empty. The back of the Head of Steam is a mess of gantry and pipework of the kind that holds a building together and also, if you are not fussy, makes a ladder of it. The alley itself runs on into a junction behind other buildings, so it is not a dead end, which was the only thing he checked before he started.

The climb was easy and it was loud. Boots on iron, twice, and a bracket that went off like a dropped spanner, and Billiam hanging there afterwards with his heart going, waiting to find out whether it had cost him anything. What he got instead was luck. Nobody came out of the door under him while he was doing it, and nobody on the street turned down the alley and looked up, and whether anyone on the inside heard him through the wall he had no way at all of knowing. Nothing happened. He kept going.

The second storey has a row of windows along it and a pitched roof above that. He got a foot braced and a hand on a bracket and put his head to the first of the windows.

A card table. Half a dozen people round it, smoke in the air, drinks going, nothing else.

So that was what was up here. He started along the row.

Moving between windows on the outside of a building is the part nobody thinks about. Each one has to be crossed, and crossing it means putting yourself flat against the glass with the street's light behind you, and the whole time he was paying so much attention to not being a silhouette that he had very little left over for actually looking in. The glass was smoky. People had their backs to him. He got past three windows and three rooms and did not recognise a single face in any of them, so he kept going.

At the fourth window the handholds stopped.

The gantry does not carry on past it. To get to the next one he would have to go across the sill itself, on his feet, in full view of the room. Nobody does that by accident and nobody inside would think he had. He stood on the bracket with his fingers in the brickwork and looked at it for a while.

Then he threw a sound across the room at them.² He put a mumble of voices just inside their door, the sound of two people about to come in, and every head in that room turned towards it at once, and he went across the window at a scramble

²**Thaumaturgy.** The first working an apprentice is given, and the smallest. It makes a noise, or a shadow, or a smell of burning, and nothing else whatever. Billiam's makes a sound exactly where he wants one, and it is gone as soon as it has been heard.

while their backs were to him.

There were people leaving. He could not see their faces, only two backs going out through the door, and he got that much and no more.

Downstairs, in the main room, Felix watched the fourth door on the balcony open and two men come out of it. Big guild coats, both of them. Nobody he knew. They went along the balcony and down and out, and behind them the fourth room stood empty.

* * *

A man came in off the street with a lute case on his back, went to the bar, and put himself down at Calder's elbow.

Calder gave him the half-second you give a stranger at a bar and went back to his beer. Heavier brows than you would expect on a face that shape. A beard cut in a style nobody wears any more. A nose that sits a little off straight. A nobody.

"Calder." The man said it out of the side of his mouth without turning his head. "It's me. Aeska."

Calder's eyes came all the way open.

"Don't worry," Aeska said, to the bar rather than to him. "It's only me."

"Okay." Calder got his face back. "Okay."

"What's the situation like?"

So Calder gave him the room. He did not know what Billiam was doing, which he admitted first. Then Lark and Felix, over at the table on the left, without pointing at them. Then the two tables he had marked, and why he had marked them. Then the balcony.

"But also, interestingly, there is some doors upstairs there. Five, I think it was. And especially the one, the decorated one, is busy with the servers." He took a drink. "So there is some, I would say, VIP persons probably. Based on the decorations and the servants going over there."

"Okay. So there might be a lot of potential targets that we can question."

"Indeed. Indeed." Calder set the tankard down. "Yeah, I'm not sure how we could get any info from the rooms. But I'm thinking if I should try and go play the dice games with these guys."

Aeska turned and looked at him, properly, for the first time.

"Well. Do you even know how to play?"

"A little bit. Not the best." Calder shrugged. "But I hope that I'm not losing too much money."

“And how does a scholar like you know how to play a tavern game like this?” Aeska had his drink halfway to his mouth and stopped it there, and something in his face had gone bright and sideways. “I knew scholars in my time. They went to pubs. They did not come out of them knowing this.”

“My parents are engineers.” Calder did not hesitate anywhere in it. “They play dice. We played it together.”

“I have never once played dice with my parents.” Aeska said it slowly. “Though that may be a matter of my situation rather than the game. Go on.”

“It’s a nice chill game. Not for money, obviously. Not with the parents.” Calder shrugged. “That would be, oh man, I lost, they kicked me out.”

“Dice aside, then.” Aeska put the drink down. “You also seem to know exactly which of these people is a criminal and which is not. How can you be sure? To me this is any tavern on any evening, except that most of them are Porters.”

“I stood here a couple of minutes and watched.” Calder did not turn round. “I think I am getting decent at it. Being observant for the fine detail is a good academic property. And people who have a little more to hide tend to crouch a little more, even though they never notice they are doing it.”

Aeska let a good long second go by.

“Apparently you are more than just a regular scholar.”

“Well.”

“But if you think the game is the way, then try it.” Aeska was already going into his coat. “Do you even have enough money to sit down at one?”

Calder had to ask what people bet in a place like this, and the answer was pennies to start and a mark or two by the end of a table, which was survivable.

“Yeah, I think I have still enough savings to play a couple of rounds. Unless they go absolute mayhem.”

“Okay. I am going to spend this wisely.” Aeska put two marks on the bar and slid them across with one finger. “Just don’t go spend it all in one place.”

“All in red.”

“All in red. Double your money.” Aeska picked up his own drink. “Okay. I’ll try to do my own investigation.”

“Can I ask what do you plan to do?”

“Well. I am planning to find out who our VIP guests are.”

“I see.” Calder turned a little further in. “And then I also tell you that I have, as I spent so much time studying, that I know the message. So don’t get scared if I whisper into your head. I know it sounds a little bit weird.”

“Well.” Aeska considered the last three days. “From what I have seen, that is one of the least weird things I have seen, after everything we have been dealing with.”

He pushed off the bar. He did not know it yet, but before the night was out, one of the five of them was going to do something that none of them had a word for.

* * *

Over at the table, Felix had watched a stranger walk up to Calder and lean in and start talking into his ear, and got there in two steps.

“Oh, that’s him.” Lark said. “Oh. Okay. That’s smart to disguise yourself like that.”

She had been sitting on an idea for a few minutes and she put it out now.

“We could slip a note to the server that is carrying the drinks up to those rooms.” She had both hands round her cup. “That’s one way to get a person out of there. If we wrote something on it that would require them to leave. However. That’s just a surface idea. And I don’t have money to go gamble with those guys at the corner.”

Felix was never going to be the one at the dice table. He does not know the game, and he would lose his way into it long before he learned anything from anybody sitting round it. What he did instead was take her idea off her and turn it over. A note going up on a tray, in a hand nobody in that room would know, saying the one thing that would bring a man out through a locked door and down a staircase. He could not think yet what that thing would be. He kept hold of the shape of it anyway.

Lark got up, leaving her cup where it stood. Billy had been out there on his own a long while now, she said, and somebody had better go and see about him.

Outside, the street was as full as it had been when they arrived and she could not see Billiam anywhere in it.

She tried the side of the building next, and at the mouth of the alley she stopped, and looked down it, and then looked up.

He was on the wall. Twelve feet up, spread across the brickwork with his back to the street, edging along a row of lit windows in a building full of the people who had taken his boss, and nobody in the whole of the Furlong had happened to glance down that alley in the last ten minutes.

Lark was startled to see him that high up. She turned her back on him at once and set herself at the corner of the alley mouth, hands holding onto the corner and her covered face studying the street, ready to stop anybody who might walk in and look up.

* * *

Felix went and stood at the bar next to Aeska.

“So.” Aeska did not look round. “Did you find out anything?”

“Nothing useful. Lark has gone outside to find Billy.”

“Are you by any chance good at dice?”

“No.”

“I didn’t think so.” Aeska set his glass down. “Well. I am going to try to talk to this barman and get as much information as I can about our VIP guest in the room upstairs. I honestly don’t know what you can do, but, yeah, it’s better if I’m alone while talking to the barman. Maybe you could try to see if you can eavesdrop on any conversation or something like that.”

“Sure. I’ll just walk through the crowd listening in.”

Felix went on through the crowd, listening. He did not hear anything worth carrying back. He did notice something else.

Scratchers. The little rat-shaped constructs that run deliveries all over Parvo, low along the skirting, six legs going. There were several of them working the floor of the Head of Steam, in and out through holes cut in the base of the walls for exactly that purpose, and what they were carrying was not drinks and not plates. It was paper. Messages going between the kitchen and the serving staff and wherever else a message needs to go in a building this size, all evening, under everybody’s feet, and no one in the room so much as looked down at them.

Something started in Felix then, an idea, or the front edge of one, that he did not yet understand himself.

* * *

Before Calder went over to the table, he worked out what he had to sell.

You do not get information out of people by asking for it. You get it by having some, and by the look of the men he was about to sit down with, they would want paying in the same currency he wanted paying in. The only genuinely interesting thing he knew was standing at the bar in a false beard.

So he put a few words across the room.

Hey. Based on what Lark said, you are probably the hot topic at the moment. Is there some info I can give out of you if needed? Like where you could have been. And then, because it had occurred to him halfway through: Oh, and by the way, you can reply to these messages.

A pause, and then Aeska in his head, with his teeth together.

I would prefer you gave nothing at all about my whereabouts. I am rather a hot topic. Give them something false if you must, the essence turning up at some other scrapyard, anything like that.

We are not going back to the Plumb and Bob. So I can say you have been seen there and nothing else.

If you can keep it to rumour, and only if you have to. As vague as you can make it.

There were three of them at the table and one empty chair.

The one who had drawn Calder over was a big shaven-headed human in a Porter's coat, somewhere in his thirties, with a set of scars across his face of a kind a man does not pick up carrying crates. Next to him sat an older man in a waistcoat and shirt with a heavy drooping moustache and long greying hair, no guild colours anywhere on him, and nothing else obviously wrong except that he did not look like a man who worked for anyone. The third was a Darkin woman of about twenty, done through the ears and the brow and the lip with more metal than the other two put together, dressed as a porter and built like one.

All three of them stopped and looked up as he came over with his beer.

"Oh, yeah. You guys are playing this game." Calder put a hand on the back of the empty chair. "I've heard it's kind of fun. May I join?"

The Darkin woman looked him up and down and made a small sound through her nose.

"You sure you want to play? We play for money here." A beat. "Good money."

"Yeah. I can play a couple of rounds, let's see how it goes." He sat down anyway. "If I lose too hard, then I'm afraid I need to leave."

"All right. Well. Take a seat."

Runs is three dice of three different sizes, and you want consecutive numbers across all of them, which beats any total. Failing that, the highest total takes it. The sting is that everybody has to throw one die again after the first cast, so a good hand has to be broken by the man holding it.

They each put a penny in and threw.

Nobody made a run. The moustache man ended on twelve and Calder needed a three to tie him and a four to beat him, and he threw the three, and the table made a noise.

There is a version of that moment where Calder throws again honestly and loses. What happened instead was that he picked up the middle die with the tie still hanging in the air, made a show of blowing on it, threw it, and put it down showing a six that it had not been showing when it landed. He did it about as well as it can be done. Nobody at that table saw anything at all.

Fifteen. The moustache man went for the long shot, needed a one, did not get it, and Calder scooped the pot and was three pennies up on the evening.

"Yeah. Not too bad at this." The moustache man was looking at him with his chin on his hand. "You said you were a beginner."

"Ah. Sometimes lucky, I guess." Calder winked at him.

"We don't really like lucky people at this table, I tell you." He was smiling while he said it. "But look. You're on your way to a second round. What do you say? Double. Two penny in."

"Sure. Let's go double."

The second round came down to Calder on fifteen and the shaven-headed man on fifteen, and the shaven-headed man went to throw again, and then did not throw again.

He put one hand flat over his dice and tilted it. When the hand came away the three was a four and his total was sixteen. It was the clumsiest piece of work Calder had seen at a gaming table in years. The Darkin woman saw it. The moustache man saw it. There was not a person at that table who had missed it.

Calder turned his head and looked him in the eyes, and kept looking.

"So this is how we are going to play."

The big man fumbled his dice, which told everybody what they already knew, and then squared his shoulders and put his jaw out, which is the only move left when you have been caught and you are the largest man at the table.

"What are you trying to say?"

"I'm just saying that, you know." Calder reached out and began drawing the coppers in the middle towards himself, one short stack at a time, in no particular hurry. "It seems that this round of beer is on me. And I'll take the money from the centre."

He did not raise his voice. He did not stand up. He did not stop collecting.

The shaven-headed man was twice him across the shoulders and could have finished it with one arm, and he sat there with his hand still flat on the table looking for something in the face across from him. It was not there. No fear in it, no bluff, no hurry, none of the small apologies a man makes with his body when he has overreached and would like to be let off. A young man in long sleeves and gloves, counting coppers into his palm. The calm of it was what made them nervous.

Then the hand came off the table.

"Yeah. Yeah, no." He sat back. "Drinks are on you next round."

Calder raised two fingers for a server without breaking his eye line, and ordered for the table.



Aeska had the barman to himself.

The man was tall and going bald and had been a considerable size once and still was. His left sleeve was stitched up at the shoulder, flat and empty. He wore a monocle in his right eye and looked down his nose over the top of it, which is a way of looking at people Aeska has been on the receiving end of in much better rooms than this one. Then the man arrived in front of him with a grin across his whole face, and none of it fitted together.

“So.” Aeska put his elbows on the bar. “Good business here, I see. Is it always like this?”

“A new face.” The grin widened. “I’m delighted to make your acquaintance. They call me the Baron.”

“The Baron.” Aeska said it back with exactly the right weight. “That is a fitting name for a man like you.”

The Baron beamed at him. He told him the place was doing very good business indeed, that he was happy to see all his Porter’s Guild friends in it, and that he had been one himself before the accident.

Aeska asked about the accident, and apologised for asking, and was waved at.

“I was a porter a long time. Since almost the city began. And then one day we were hauling a crate up the side of one of the warehouses in the Core.” He turned the stitched shoulder towards him. “Crate fell off. Boom, straight on the arm, lopped it right off. Quick and easy.”

Two thousand tellings had worn it down to that.

“Difficult to be a porter after that with the one arm. So I retired, got a nice payout from the guild, and set up this place.” He was pleased about it and did not hide it. “These Porter’s Guild folk, they respect one of their own. The Spire’s just over that way, so they come in after work. Always busy.”

Aeska looked round the room once more, slowly, as though something had just occurred to him.

“With this busyness, I’ve noticed that there seems to be something missing that I’ve seen in a lot of other places. And that’s live music.” He turned back. “Have you ever considered that?”

“Well, you know, we had a couple of pretty bad musicians, honestly, that used to come around, and we just felt like it wasn’t really adding to the vibe of the place.” The Baron pulled a face. “A lot of the guys here get a bit rowdy after a few drinks and things, and it becomes quite a noisy environment as it is. So we didn’t really feel like music would help with that situation.”

“Ah.” Aeska let it hang, and then came at it from underneath. “Then I have

picked a poor room to walk into, because I am a wandering musician, and I am rather down on work.” He smiled at him. “This is a new part of town for me. I saw the crowd coming through that door and I thought, there is a man who knows what his room wants. What do you say?”

He was very good at this before he learned to do it on purpose.

“Well.” The Baron leaned in on his one elbow. “Look. If you want to make some real money, not this riff-raff here.” He jerked his head at his own customers, all of them, fondly. “There’s money to be made in doing some private shows for our VIP guests. Some of the highest members of the Porter’s Guild drink here, I’ll have you know, and I’m sure they’d be more than happy to have a little entertainment for their games. They’ll tip a lot better, too. A lot richer than the run-of-the-mill folk we get in here.”

“The doors upstairs.” Aeska did not look up at the balcony. “Those would be the ones. And I have my instrument with me.”

“You’re a stand-up chap and incredibly persuasive.” The Baron straightened, thoroughly enjoying himself. “So how about a baptism by fire. The room at the end there is our VIP room, and it has some particularly special guests in it tonight. They’ll throw you out faster than not if you’re not what you say you are. And if they don’t, there’ll be plenty in it for you.”

“Then send me up.”

Somebody put a hand on his shoulder from behind.

“Good luck,” Felix said, and left a small blessing sitting on him where the hand had been, and walked off into the crowd before Aeska could decide whether a strange man touching him was in character or not.³

“Susie.” The Baron was leaning out over the bar. “Susie, come here.”

A young Darkin woman came over with a full tray already balanced on her hand.

“You’re delivering that up to the VIP room? Take him with you.” He stopped. “I never caught your name.”

“Valor.” One beat, and not a long one. “Valor. A travelling musician.”

Susie was already moving, and Aeska picked up the case and went after her.

“Valor, was it? Come along, come along.” She took the stairs without letting the tray tilt. “Harsh audience you’ve picked for a first gig. Hope they like you.”

* * *

³**Guidance.** A small blessing laid on somebody who is about to attempt one particular thing. It sits on the skin, faintly, until it is spent, and then it is gone.

The drinks came, and the table stopped playing to drink them, which was the entire purpose of the exercise.

Calder took his time over his. He had caught a man cheating in front of his own friends and then sold him a way out of it for the price of a round, and the three of them had rearranged themselves around him accordingly. He did not waste it by being pleasant, and he did not start talking until they had all had a drink out of the glasses he had bought them.

“So.” He turned his tankard on the wood. “What is actually going on? Like, there has been so much funny business with this Porter’s Guild. You guys are attacking kids on the open streets, beating up everyone, taking people out from their jobs.” A risky line to take, but on the back of what he had just done at that table it was a line he could hold. He let a little weariness into it, a man whose quarter has gone badly. “You know, this is bad for business. Especially for me and my boss.”

Nobody asked him who his boss was. He had been braced for it all the way over and it never came. In a room like that, a man who names his employer is a man who has to account for himself, and Calder had not accounted for himself once that evening.

It was the moustache man who answered him. The other two did not open their mouths again for the rest of it, and Calder had worked out why: the big one was there to be big, the young woman was there to be paid, and the old man with the drooping moustache was the one who decided things.

“Well, look. It’s not really our business necessarily what everyone in the Porter’s Guild is up to, right? So I can’t exactly speak on account of us here on this table.” He had his drink in both hands. “But I’ve heard that there’s a bit of, let’s say, aggravation in Evan’s crew.” He looked up. “You know Evan?”

Calder went through what he had.

There had been an Evan in the Porter’s Guild somewhere at the edge of a conversation he was not part of. Not the top of it. The top of it is Sasha Langford and everybody knows that. Somebody high enough that the name came up while people were discussing the guild rather than the men who work for it. He could not have said what the position was, or sworn it was the same Evan.

He nodded as if the name meant something to him.

“Yeah, well. I don’t know exactly, like.” The moustache man settled into it. “Evan’s crew’s been kind of pissed off about some dealings what went wrong, or some shit that’s gone down. And I don’t know. I got the impression they haven’t been paid for something, or they missed out on something, and they’ve been kind of hunting down the culprits.” He shrugged with his eyebrows. “You know how it is. You got to make sure people pay their debts. Can’t leave any loose ends,

because people start thinking you're a bit soft. Can't leave them hanging. So as far as I can tell, they've been on a bit of a warpath trying to rectify these mistakes. And people get to hear about it, right? So they've got to hold their reputation up at the same time."

"Yeah. Yeah, as long as it doesn't last too long. We don't want to make any rearrangements." Calder let that settle and then asked the only question he had actually come to this table to ask. "And I assume, in this hypothetical case, we could buy some people back from those."

"You mean if they've got one of your people?"

Calder looked at him sharply and nodded.

"Depends." The old man pushed his lower lip out. "If they took him for a ransom, sure. If they took him for what he knows, you're not getting him back, not unless you hand over the same thing he's sitting on. But debts? They don't normally take people prisoner at all. That's a lot of work. They beat you up and then you pay. Taking a man and keeping him, that's a whole other kettle of fish, and most won't bother."

"No."

"And the problem is you're using the guild's own cells for it, and that gets involved. People inside start asking. Who's this in here? What's he done?" He tipped his drink towards Calder. "If you want a thing kept quiet from Sasha and that lot, cells are the last place you put it. So if they've got your boy and he's in the spire for certain, that's a harder one to negotiate. You know what I'm saying?"

"Yeah. I know." Calder said it like a man agreeing about freight rates. "I know. It's business after all."

He did not push it any further. He had a name, and he had a reason, and he had been told by a man who deals in it that whoever was holding Shrapnel in that tower was hiding him from his own Headman. A stranger who asks one more question than that stops being a businessman.

So he finished his beer and stood up, and took Aeska's two marks out of his pocket, and put them down on the wood in front of the moustache man.

"This evening is on me," he said. "And we never had this conversation."

Nobody asked his name. He had not offered it, and he was into the crowd before any of them thought to.

Every word he had given that table was a lie, and he had handed them over so gently that not one of the three had felt the weight of a single one.

* * *

Felix went and locked himself in a stall in the gentlemen's, which is the only room in a building like that where anybody is ever alone.

He had spent several minutes trying to get a word to a scratcher and had got nowhere. To speak into a thing you have to be able to see it, and the scratchers ran the skirting behind a forest of legs and never held still long enough to be found. He stood in the stall and turned it over. Get one on its own, or do it out in the open where everyone could watch him talking to the floor. Neither was any good.

He stared at the back of the door and thought hard. *How do I get in among them.*

And then something happened that made every strange thing of the last week look ordinary. Felix began to convulse, and his body set about answering the question.

It came up through him as heat and then as light, essence and sparks going off under the skin as though he were a made thing with a fault in it. Then the whole of him folded down and inward, smaller and smaller, until what was left crunched into something the size of a shoebox on the tiles.⁴

It hurt more than anything else that has happened to him this week, and a good deal has.

And then he was on the floor with six legs.

Scratchers are not rats, though that is what everyone calls them. They are a tube on legs, somewhere between a rat and a centipede, and the whole city is full of little holes cut in the bottoms of walls to let them through. Felix went out of the stall and out of the room through one of those, along the skirting behind a hundred pairs of boots, and round behind the bar, where he found what he was looking for.

Three of them, sitting in a bank against the wall, doing nothing. They do not need charging. It is simply where they wait.

"You are not like us," one of them said.

"Yes. I know."

They did not know what to make of him and they were not built to work it out. Something in them registered a shape that was a scratcher and a thing that was not a scratcher, and after a moment they settled on the shape, because that is what they are for.

"What do you want?"

"I need some messages from upstairs. From the VIP rooms."

⁴**Wild shape.** Never named on tape, but of a kind with the change that lets a person put on an animal's body and go about in it. It was new to him. He did not decide on it so much as reach for something and find his body already answering, and it hurt a very great deal.

“Messages.” The nearest one lifted the front half of its own head, and it came away on a hinge, and inside the tube of its body there was a cavity with all of the mechanism packed round the walls to make room for it. “Messages in here.”

There was nothing in it.

They carry paper. That is all they do with it. They take a folded note from one hand in one room and run it along a wall to another hand in another room. What is written on it goes past them the way weather goes past a wall. The three of them had no more idea what had been carried up and down those stairs all evening than the stairs did.

Felix looked into the open cavity for a while.

Then he worked out that he had one too.

There is a chute running up the side of the staircase for them, because no scratcher was ever going to manage stairs, and he took it, and came up onto the balcony floor at the level of the skirting board.

Ahead of him a young Darkin woman with a tray was walking towards the door at the end of the corridor, and behind her, carrying a lute case, went a man he knew.

* * *

Susie rapped the frosted glass twice, and was through the door before anybody inside had time to answer it. She crossed the room, put the tray down on a side table, and came straight back out. Six seconds, start to finish, and not one of the four of them looked up at her.

Aeska stood in the open doorway.

There were four people at a card table in a room with a good deal of smoke in it.

Two of them he knew from other people’s descriptions. A large broad woman past middle age in a heavy forest green overcoat, with her cheeks gone ruddy from drinking, leaning back in her chair. Beside her a young blonde Aela, lean, with a scar running down through both lips and the chin, sitting perfectly still.

The third was a man in a green suit that had cost more than everything else in the building. Jewellery on both hands, hair slicked flat back off a high forehead, Porter’s Guild green worked into the cloth, and eyes that glowed a soft yellow in the lamplight. He had the manner before he had said a word. Aeska grew up among people who have that manner and can spot it across a room.

The fourth was cloaked in black and wearing a porcelain white mask.

Aeska's eye went to him first and found nothing it could use. The mask gave him no face, the cloak gave him no hands, and the man himself did not move at all. It was like looking at a chair that had been left facing the wrong way, and the longer he looked the less he liked it, and he made himself look elsewhere.

So he took the nobleman instead, and worked at him for the two seconds he had before somebody spoke. He had seen this man before. Somewhere with good lighting and a great many people in it. A party, at a guess, years ago, in the life he does not have any more.

Outside, twelve feet up, Billiam had got round to the last window and was looking into the same room from the other side.

Low in the corner of it, through a hole cut for exactly this, a scratcher came in and stopped where the skirting met the wall.

Aeska stepped in and shut the door behind him.

"Good evening. My name is Valor. I am a travelling bard, and I've had a talk with the barman downstairs, and he has set me up here to provide you with some musical entertainment for the night." He put a hand on the case. "May I, so I would like to ask, may I perform for you?"

"Oh, that Baron is more than kind to us. How exciting." The nobleman had turned right round in his chair. "We haven't had music in here for a long time, and I've always said to him, you know, why are we skimping on the luxuries of life? You know, music is an art. Please. Please." He gestured. "The corner. I assume you're a musician?"

"A musician, and a hungry one." Aeska had the lute out of the case before he finished saying it. "Which is the most dangerous kind to put in a corner, sir, because we play as though we are being paid by the note."

The nobleman laughed out loud at that.

The woman in green watched him with the loose amiability of somebody four drinks in. The Aela looked at him with the same flat total attention he had presumably been giving the wall a moment earlier, and did not change his expression once, and did not stop. The man in the mask turned his head in Aeska's general direction and gave every appearance of not caring whether the music happened.

Aeska had been listening to the room downstairs all evening and he made a decision about what to play. Not the light rolling tavern stuff, the wavy strumming thing that a pub full of drunk men ignores. Something with an edge on it, faster and harder, the sort of thing that suits a building full of people who lift things for a living.

He played very well. He always does, but he did it there with a false nose on, in a locked room with four people in it, two of whom had put his friend on the floor of Oblong Square, and it did not get into his hands once.

He played one song and then he stopped.

The nobleman clapped. Then he looked round at the other three, and the look did the work, and the large woman started clapping too. The Aela brought his hands together four or five times with no expression whatever on his face and stopped.

The man in the porcelain mask did not clap. Aeska never saw his hands at all.

“So.” The nobleman leaned forward. “I haven’t seen you play before, but you play wonderfully. Are you a frequent travelling musician around these parts? Or have I heard of you, or heard you anywhere before?”

“You have not, and nobody has.” Aeska had the answer ready and let none of the readiness show. “I am a musician down on his luck in a new part of town. Your Baron at the front seemed interested, but he wanted me sent up here first to find out whether I was lying about myself.” He inclined his head an inch. “I take it I was not.”

“Yes. Wonderful, wonderful. Yes, I love it.” He was delighted. “Yes, you really must find a way to play here. Improve the whole establishment. Like I’ve been saying to Baron for years, you know, this place needs a little bit more lively music, something to keep the spirits up. People always down in the dumps and sat in their drinks and that sort of thing.” He spread his hands. “You know, I’m happy to see there’s a man of the arts here in this place.” A pause. “You don’t play dice, do you?”

“No. Unfortunately my skills are in music and not in games.”

“Unfortunate. These lot here are useless.”

The ducats in front of him were stacked three deep. In front of everybody else at that table there was bare wood.

“Yeah, well. I’m very happy that there is someone who appreciates the music that I play.” Aeska had the case in his hand and had started, very slightly, to move. “And yes. I hope I can play here more often.”

“Of course. Of course. Well, it’s a pleasure.” The nobleman put out a ringed hand. “My name is Evan. Evan Langford.”

“Yes. Like I said, my name is Valor.” Aeska took it. “Thank you for having me, and enjoy your night.”

“Of course. Anytime you’re in the vicinity, please come and, yes, regale us. Very, very happy. Even if my compatriots here don’t have the taste for music, I certainly do.”

Aeska went out and got the door closed behind him before he let his face do anything.

Langford. There is one Langford in this city that matters, and he sits on the City Council, and he runs the Porter’s Guild, and his name is Sasha. Put that

beside the suit and the manner and the age of the man and a party some years ago in a house where the Volans were invited, and it comes out one way only.

He had just played a song for the Headman's son.